

Birds

Our next-door neighbour came round with a photo and a story of how a bird flew right into his garden to capture a pigeon. He managed to get a photo before the raptor flew away leaving a pile of feathers.

It was a

Peregrine Falcon *falco peregrinus*

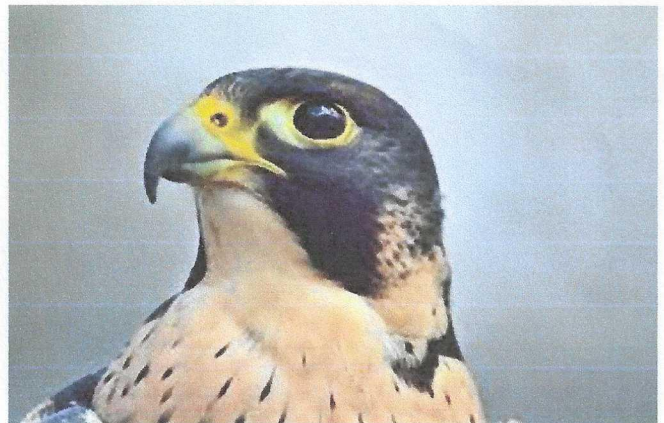
They're not often seen over the park so we're lucky Colin caught this one.



The peregrine is a large and powerful falcon, swift and agile in prey-chasing flight. It has long, broad, pointed wings and a relatively short tail. It's blue-grey above, with a blackish top of the head and an obvious black 'moustache' that contrasts with its white face. Its breast is pale and finely barred.

Its cere, the waxy, fleshy covering at the base of its upper beak, is yellow, as are its feet. Its beak and claws are black.

Its upper beak is notched near the tip, enabling falcons to kill by severing the spinal column at the neck of its prey.



The strongholds of the breeding birds in the UK are the uplands of the north and west and rocky seacoasts. Suitable nesting sites restrict peregrines to areas where cliff-ledges, quarry faces, crags, or sea-cliffs are available.

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But nowadays, they have started to use man-made constructions, especially tall buildings as nest sites and an abundance of prey such as pigeons and ducks.

Tree nesting occurs only rarely in the UK.

The peregrine feeds primarily on birds, which it catches in flight. It spots the prey at distance



and, once positioned correctly, it stoops at high speed for the catch.

A peregrine stoop with folded wings can reach speeds of up to 200 mph. To enable the bird to breathe at this speed, it has special baffles in its nostrils, which control breathing.

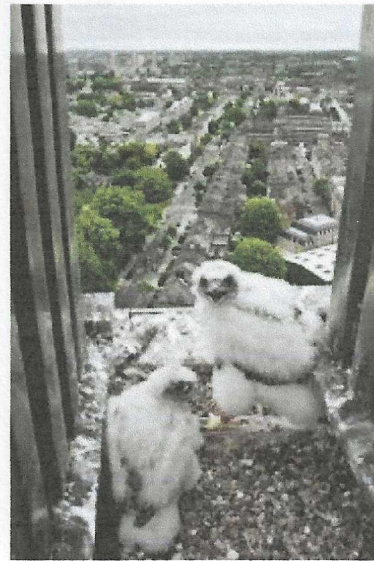
The high-speed stoop means that the peregrine must catch its prey on the wing to avoid injuring itself on impact. But it's not always successful at speed so sometimes it makes a surprise attack at lower speeds, snatching prey, very often pigeons, from a perch or the ground – as in Colin's garden.

A favourite place not too far away where it is possible to view its magnificent stoop is Symonds Yat with its viewpoint over the River Severn.

Peregrine numbers were at a low point in the 1960s - human persecution and pesticides such as DDT. But improved legislation and protection has helped them to recover.

However, they are still persecuted - birds are illegally killed to prevent predation on game birds and racing pigeons. They also have eggs and chicks taken for collections and falconry.

Peregrines are a Schedule 1 listed species of The Wildlife and Countryside Act.



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Throughout history the peregrine falcon has been a well-respected falconry bird due to its strong hunting ability, high trainability, versatility, and availability via captive breeding.

The sport of Falconry probably dates back to 2,000 BC in Mesopotamia. It certainly became a popular sport and status symbol. In fact In medieval England, the only bird a knave was legally allowed to keep was a kestrel.



D'you remember *A Kestrel for a Knave*? Published in 1968 by author Barry Hines, set in a mining area in Northern England, Billy Casper, troubled at home and school, finds and trains a kestrel whom he names "Kes".

This list from the *The Book of St Albans*, 1486, provides the hierarchy of raptors and the social ranks for which each bird was supposedly appropriate.

- Emperor: eagle, vulture, merlin
- King: gyrfalcon
- Prince: gentle falcon: a female peregrine falcon
- Duke: falcon of the loch
- Earl: peregrine falcon
- Baron: buzzard
- Knight: saker falcon
- Squire: lanner falcon
- Lady: merlin
- Young man: hobby
- Yeoman: goshawk
- Poor man: male falcon
- Priest: sparrowhawk
- Holy water clerk: sparrowhawk

A Peregrine with its headdresses 1837

In the UK and parts of Europe, falconry probably reached its zenith in the 17th century, but soon faded as firearms became the tool of choice for hunting.

However, it's still a sport today.

